✦ CAMPFIRE HORROR TALES

HALLOWEEN SPECIAL

Jack-o'-Lantern

A young girl on the cusp of growing up, goes out with her friends to chase the magic of Halloween, but is instead haunted forevermore.

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It was Halloween and Elsie was thirteen.

Every year, without fail, her family carved pumpkins together. It was one of those traditions her father insisted on keeping, even as they grew older. And he was an incredible pumpkin carver. He'd bring home the biggest pumpkins he could find, line them up on the kitchen table, and let each of his five kids choose their own. Some would have bumps and warty-looking surfaces, or strange shapes that would inspire alien renditions, fat trolls, and monsters from nightmares....

It was a healthy competition, albeit unfair. His were always the best, and Elsie, being the oldest, would usually come in a close second. The kids ranged in age from three to thirteen. So, at three, Shelly was, well, not really doing much but providing the vision, and often a cutesy kind of face that everyone agreed didn't count – even though it was often declared the winner just to be kind, much to the dismay of Jon, who was seven and still wanted to be the default winner he was for the same reason a few years earlier. Poor Robert, who was nine didn't even remember ever winning.

But it was the time together: the gooey guts, the smell of the roasting seeds, the fighting, Dad yelling not to put your hands inside while stabbing the thick flesh to cut out the often uneven eyes.... It was terrifying in some ways to have so many kids sitting around with the sharpest kitchen knives, the marker-drawn faces slowly melting off the freshly washed, slippery skin.....

But Elsie was thirteen, and going trick-or-treating alone with her friends this year. She was preoccupied with that, and so little dedication went into the effort this year. A basic pumpkin face, triangle eyes and a smaller triangle nose, and a smile

with picket teeth.... That was fine this year. She just wanted to hurry away from the table that was more of a pumpkin massacre.... and get ready to go out with her friends. They were going to meet up at the park a few blocks from her house, and she was going out as a dead girl.... She wasn't sure yet what she was.... but something dead..... dark, bloody and somehow... older?

Besides, her sister Mel was getting at her, tormenting her about going out now that she was a teenager. "People will make fun of you." "No one will give you candy!"

Her father reassured her as she was leaving the table... "You're only a child once, enjoy it for as long as you can." His voice trailed off as she sauntered down the hall to do her ghastly makeup.....

She didn't realize this would be her last year to enjoy it...

She left the house out the side door, yelling "Bye!" to Mom, Dad, her brothers and sisters, avoiding the bulky coat her mom would have tried to make her wear and the camera Dad always had ready.... There was a hard "no posting rule" in effect anyways. She had a selfie if they really wanted; she'd share that.

Elsie met her friends down the road...bloody costumes and terrifying masks really did make them look like a gang of goons! They had a real presence about them. Sally's head looked bashed in with caked blood in her matted hair. She was a fantastic makeup artist.

Dean had gone full Terrifier – fricking awesome, and a garbage bag for candy collection, genius....

Rolly was a kind of knock-off Pennywise, maybe the Temu version..... but it worked.....

She fit in with the girls. Sally and Emma were both mostly blood and guts and death....

The boys were mostly clowns..... well, two for sure. She wasn't sure if Chris was a clown; he kind of just had a colourful wig on... but hey, whatever. Altogether, they sure looked fire!

They looked like misfits, still young enough but on the cusp and emanating a kind of stench that exposed the stirrings of teenage rebellion.

Sally brought a latte, Starbucks maybe.... and Chris had an energy drink.... Rockstar, tall can. Elsie was a little jealous..... she wasn't allowed coffee OR energy drinks.... well, none of them were old enough for energy drinks.....

They hung around the park a little, telling a few scary stories and talking about horror movies, most Elsie had not seen, but she was taking note and building a mental to-do list.

Her and Sally had been besties since grade 2, and now that they were in high school, they were happy to have a growing group of friends.... and Anna was definitely fun to hang out with! The boys were funny too, and a little wild, definitely suited the clown image they were portraying tonight...

They waited until the sun was down, and most of the youngest kids were out of the way before they hit the road. Elsie was glad, as she didn't want to run into her dad and siblings.... nor deal with too many little kids running around squealing,

although they did hope to scare a few...

They headed off for the main road in the village. It was lined with scarecrows and pumpkins, most houses still lit to let you know there was still enough candy to ring the bell.

It was a little chilly, but her and her friends were running around and goofing off, so the energy kept them warm enough, plus the sugar! They ate most of the candy right away. They weren't about to give it to their parents to check first; they were well able to check it for themselves now! Plus, they knew better – after years of checking, no one was going to really put a razor blade in their candy..... Geezuzzzz, what a crock that was!

Most of the homes were kind, encouraging or not bothered that they were bigger kids. Some even dumped out the tail end of their bowls into their backpacks and were turning the lights out as they walked away. A few scoffed, but still gave a candy or two.... and a few yet seemed a little nervous, especially since Anna and Rolly were abnormally tall for thirteen, and so might have made an old lady or two a little nervous.... and then there was the ghastly makeup! Not quite as cute as the little kids and their Spider-Man and Disney princess costumes.

After about an hour of walking around the main area, they noticed the lights were mostly out.... except the glow down the side road to Old Man Jack's place. He was a little off the beaten path.... clearly, many kids would pass right by, not worth the effort....

But the lights were on, and they had a little time to kill, so they ventured on down.

They got up to the house and walked up the stairs to his veranda..... He had a great big pumpkin next to his door. It was smiling at them, but with an evil grin and angry eyes.....

They rang and waited..... the pumpkin glared at them..... no one came to the door.

Sally and Rolly started yelling out – "Hey man, your lights are on, don't you know the rules!!" Everyone was laughing now – Chris chimed in, "Happy Halloween, old man, did you fall asleep in there?!"....

Then they hit the bell on repeat. "Wake up!!!"

The door opened abruptly, and Jack screamed, "Get out of here!!"

"You're too old for trick-or-treating!"

"Get off my porch now before I call the cops on the lot of ya!"

The kids froze..... he was hauntingly animated, and intimidating didn't cut it.

They kinda stammered back and muttered some bad words under their breath.... but for the most part, every one of them did exactly what he said and got the hell off his porch and fast.

He slammed the door shut and flicked off the lights so they were in total darkness.... aside from the soft glow of the sneering pumpkin.....

They all stared at each other for a moment, and then Elsie got an idea... this was something she had heard some kids do..... you know.... smashing pumpkins....

So she ran up the steps to his front door and swung her leg back full force and kicked the giant pumpkin square in the face hard. It split open on the left side of its mouth, and as it wasn't fully carved, some of the guts rolled out in a grotesque, oozing drool....

The kids all gasped, and Elsie felt kind of cool for a second, until she heard Sally yell, "Run!!!"

The lights went on upstairs, and they could see the figure of Old Man Jack peering down at them from the second floor.....

They took off screaming and ran as fast and far as they could....

They finally got to the park where they had all met up, just a few blocks from Elsie's place, and fell to the ground in fits of laughter.

"Oh my God, Elsie, that was AMAZING!!!" Anna hollered, and they all agreed it was a "kicker" of a way to end the night.

Elsie smiled and took the praise, half proud of herself for such incredible bravery, but also with a heaviness in her heart, a sadness and loss of innocence that was infusing into her soul like a tea bag of guilt in a cup of hot water....

She smiled, her heart was racing, she felt alive.... but also like something had died.

They shared a few more laughs, made plans for the following week at school, and stuffed their faces with more candy... but all of them were starting to feel the chill of the night and decided it was time to turn in..... everyone headed off in slightly different directions....

Elsie walked back toward her house alone. The streets were quiet now. It was cold and the wind was picking up.... somewhere in the distance a dog started barking.

She was tired. And she was thinking about the pumpkin, not quite sure why it was bothering her so much. It was only a pumpkin, after all. People smashed pumpkins on Halloween. It was practically a tradition for some teenagers.

But she kept imagining Old Man Jack carving it. His shrill orders for them to get off his porch.... it was like he was afraid of them. And then she had destroyed his pumpkin.

She reached her front door. Her parents had already turned off the porch light. Halloween was over for another year. She fumbled for her key. It slipped from her fingers. She bent down to retrieve it.

And then she heard something. A low, muffled groan. Followed by a wet, squelching sound.

Elsie froze.

Slowly, she turned around. And there, under only the light of the moon, stood a man. At first, she couldn't make sense of what she was looking at.

Then she recognized him. It was Old Man Jack.

He stood perfectly still, facing her. But there was something terribly wrong with his head.

He was wearing a pumpkin.

Not holding one. Not carrying one.

Wearing one.

The smashed pumpkin.

Its shell sagged over his head, split open on the left side and oozing pumpkin flesh down and onto his shoulder. Orange pulp and seeds and wet strands of pumpkin flesh clung to his coat.

He raised a lantern.

The light illuminated the carved face. The crooked eye, the uneven mouth, Elsie couldn't move. The pumpkin made another sound.

A low, wet groan. She thought she heard her name, blinked, and he was gone.

There was no movement in the street. No footsteps. No sound of a door closing. Just that same dog barking in the distance.

She grabbed her key, fumbled with the lock, and rushed inside.

"Elsie?" her father called from the kitchen.

"Yes, Dad, it's me," she managed.

"Did you have fun?"

"Yeah, it was great, but I'm tired.... going to bed."

"Okay, sweetheart, can't wait to hear all about it tomorrow."

She never told her dad about Old Man Jack, or the pumpkin. Never told anyone for that matter. But she never went trick-or-treating again. And that oozing face haunted her forevermore.